



braved rain and nerves to partake in a memorable night for the nation.

Nearly 33 crore watched on the official streaming portal, JioHotstar, as India eventually lifted the coveted trophy. As many as 39,555 fans bore witness in person at the D.Y. Patil Stadium as several generations of women cricketers silently wept with joy. One could see how badly they wanted it in how tightly Mithali Raj and Jhulan Goswami hugged the cup and the players who included them in the festivities.

This Navi Mumbai crowd has seen many of the South Africans during the WPL and made sure to chant in their honour too. Skipper Laura Wolvaardt, whose century pushed Indian fans to the brink of a breakdown, was given a standing ovation when she reached the

hundred, and again when she spoke after collecting her runner-up medal.

Beyond the field, Smriti Mandhana featured in almost every second advertisement, from personal care brand Rexona to the State Bank of India, throughout the World Cup. Several players have endorsement deals with major apparel brands like Nike, Adidas, and Puma. Jemimah's signing by Red Bull was announced days before the World Cup. Real estate player Omaxe revealed Harmanpreet as brand ambassador hours after the final. Several market analysis firms predict the monetary value of these players to rise by at least 20 per cent due to the visibility that comes with the World Cup win.

But Harmanpreet kept insisting on first living the moment in its

A day to remember: Snapshots from a momentous finale of the ICC Women's ODI World Cup.

Pics: LAVANYA LAKSHMINARAYANAN & GETTY IMAGES

entirety. Towards that end, she called all the female journalists present for a picture to celebrate "a moment for all women in the country".

The enduring image of the night, however, would be the imposing Indian captain, known for her unfiltered aggression, jumping into her father's arms, with him holding her like a five-year-old in tears. A nation's dreams had been realised, countless families' toils validated, and a bold new, lucrative future for a nation brimming with potential and promise had finally arrived.